

THE SHAPE OF THINGS

Neil LaBute

Directed by: Anne Den Bandt

Produced by Reveille Productions & Cortado Studios

THE SHAPE OF THINGS

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CHARACTERS (Réveille ensemble)

MAIN CAST

ADAM - Konstantinos Ntrekos

EVELYN - Luisa van Elise

JENNY - Ada Ozturk

PHILLIP - Casper Ootjers

ALTERNATES

ADAM - Mauricio Mattos

EVELYN - Eliabeth Salas

JENNY - Sofiia Pechynska

PHILLIP - Casper Ootjers

SETTING

A liberal arts college in a conservative midwestern town

AUTHOR'S NOTE: the / in certain lines denotes an attempt at interruption or overlap by a given character. *This play is one continuous play, therefore **there are no acts, Just scenes.***

SCENE 1 (The museum. Silence. Darkness) Volledige scene

(A young woman stands near a stretch of velvet rope. She has a can in one hand and stares up at an enormous human sculpture. After a moment, a young man [in uniform] steps across the barrier and approaches her.)

ADAM: ...you stepped over the line. Miss.

EVELYN: I know.

ADAM: Umm, you stepped over...

EVELYN: It's "Ms".

ADAM: Okay, sorry, Ms, but, ahh...

EVELYN: I meant to.

ADAM: What?

EVELYN: Step over...

ADAM: Yeah, I figured you did. I mean, the way you did it and all, kinda deliberate like.

EVELYN: I know.

ADAM: You're not supposed to do that.

EVELYN: That's why I tried it....

ADAM: Why?

EVELYN: ...to see what would happen.

ADAM: Oh. Well...me, I s'pose.

EVELYN: "Me?"

ADAM: No, I mean, I'm what happens, I guess. I have to walk over, like I've done, and ask you to take a step back. Could you, please?

EVELYN: And if someone doesn't?

ADAM: Step back?

EVELYN: What then?

ADAM: ...you're not gonna step back?

EVELYN: No...I mean, yes, I probably will, but just for interest's sake, what would you do if?

ADAM: I'm...geez, I'm not sure. I've never had anyone not step back. I've only said it, like, four times. And every time they've done it. Stepped back.

EVELYN: What if I'm your first? Non-stepper, I mean. Then what?

ADAM: Hell, I dunno...I'm off in, like, ten minutes, I'd probably just stand here, make sure you didn't touch anything.

EVELYN: Really?

ADAM: Pretty much, yeah. I'd let next shift talk to you, kick you out or whatever.

EVELYN: You wouldn't grab me or anything?

ADAM: Nah. That's too...you know. That's a total hassle, you end up rolling around on the ground, you'd probably sue the place, or me, and then...I'd get fired for doing my job. Screw that... (*Beat*) Could you do that for me, though?

EVELYN: Which, roll around on the ground or sue you?

ADAM: No, step back behind the line there... I'd appreciate it.

EVELYN: Not really.

ADAM: No, seriously, I would. I'd definitely appreciate it....

EVELYN: I mean, "not really" I'm not going to....

ADAM: I thought you just said you probably will....

EVELYN: Yeah, "probably." I decided not to.

ADAM: Hey, you're not gonna mess up my weekend with this, are you?

EVELYN: I wasn't planning on it, but...I'm not completely against it, either.

ADAM: See, if you get all crazy, then I gotta write up a report and stuff, I'm here till six, six-thirty easy, and I have a second job to get to.

EVELYN: Tonight? *Friday* night?

ADAM: Yep. Right after this, at the video store...

EVELYN: Why would anyone work two jobs on Friday night?

ADAM: ...for money.

EVELYN: Of course...sorry. (*Looks at him again*) Oh...oh, right! That's where I...I've seen you in there. You helped me once, I think.

ADAM: Yeah?

EVELYN: Uh-huh.

ADAM: With what?

EVELYN: *The Picture of Dorian Gray*...you found it in Drama, not Classics.

ADAM: Right, I remember that.

EVELYN: Somebody'd misplaced it....

ADAM: Yes...behind *Cabaret*. The "Joel Grey" fiasco...

EVELYN: Yeah, you said you found it with *Dirty Dancing* once, too, or something....

ADAM: I did, you're right...that's funny.

EVELYN: Anyway, you helped me, that was nice....

ADAM: Thanks. But, you're not gonna return the favor, right?

EVELYN: You mean the...?

(*She points back toward the velvet rope.*)

ADAM: Yeah.

EVELYN: No, sorry, I can't.

ADAM: Why is that? (*Pointing*) It's a pretty good-sized sculpture. You can see it just fine from there....

EVELYN: Truthfully? I'm building up my nerve, and if I go back over, I'll probably be a big wuss about it and take off....

ADAM: About what? The "wuss" part, I mean....

EVELYN: I was going to deface the statue.

ADAM: Oh. Oh... (*Pointing*) Is that paint?

EVELYN: Yes.

ADAM: Great...

(*They share a smile.*)

ADAM: Paint's not really the best thing to have in a museum. Why do you have that?

EVELYN: I was going to do something to the nude. Mess it up or...

ADAM: What, you mean, like, colour it or something?

EVELYN: I was thinking more of painting a big dick on it, but whatever....

ADAM: Well, you could still colour it in...the dick.

(*EVELYN smiles at this.*)

EVELYN: True. It might look kinda weird....

ADAM: Oh, I think a graffiti penis is gonna be plenty odd already.... (*Beat*) So, right over the leaves there, or just a free-floating number?

EVELYN: Probably anatomically correct. I mean, if you're gonna do it, why not....

ADAM: ...do it right? Absolutely. And, would "why" be completely out of the question here?

EVELYN: Why the "dick"?

ADAM: Uh-huh. I mean, since I basically have to jump you now if you lift that can up, it'd help with my report....

EVELYN: Because I don't like art that isn't true.

ADAM: "True." What do you mean?

EVELYN: False art. I hate that....

ADAM: No, I understand the words you've used here, although they're both pretty subjective: "art." "Truth."

EVELYN: Exactly! That's the beauty of art...it's subjective.

ADAM: Right, but see, I don't know what you're referring to then. I mean, specifically.... *(Beat)* Didn't Oscar Wilde say something like, "In art there is no such thing as a universal truth..." Or whatever?

EVELYN: Yes...very good. "A truth in art is that whose contradictory is also true." Right, but that's an *aesthetic*. I'm talking about practicalities. Censorship.

(She points.)

This sculpture. It's fake, it's not real. Therefore, false art...

ADAM: No, it's a Fornecelli, it definitely is. I read the little thingie there one time....

EVELYN: Yes, but the leaf cluster isn't.

ADAM: It's not?

EVELYN: No.

ADAM: What is it, a pastie or something, like strippers have?

EVELYN: It's plaster...it was added by a committee who had complaints from local townspeople.

ADAM: Really?

EVELYN: Uh-huh.

ADAM: I didn't know that...

EVELYN: They made a petition and got that put on, thereby removing its subjectivity as art.

ADAM: When did they do this?

EVELYN: Seven or eight years ago now, I think. Before I got here, anyway.

ADAM: Huh.

EVELYN: See, they objected to his "thing." The shape of it. Said it was too *life-like*.

(Beat) It's supposed to be "god," you know...that's what pisses 'em off.

ADAM: Huh.

EVELYN: No, and I don't know why...we're always calling him "the creator." *(Beat)*

Look at it, you can see the...see right behind the grapes there, you can just see his....

ADAM: Yeah...he's not really supposed to have one of those, is he?

ADAM: ...grapes. Yes. You're absolutely, huh. Didn't even cover him properly.

Shoddy craftsmanship!

EVELYN: I mean, if you're gonna do it, at least....

ADAM: ...exactly. Do it right. *(Beat)* But why deface the thing? I mean, just out of curiosity. Why not, say, knock the plaster off and expose his...you know...cluster... if you're trying to....

EVELYN: Because. That's so...expected.

ADAM: Ahh...so, you're a student, then, or is this just basic anarchy?

EVELYN: Yep. Student.

ADAM: Me too.

EVELYN: Yeah? What's your emphasis?

ADAM: Ummm...taking out school loans, primarily, but I do sit in on a few English classes. You're in art?

EVELYN: Mmmm-hmmm. M F A.

ADAM: Oh.

EVELYN: Applied theory and crit...

ADAM: So, is this, like, a project?

EVELYN: No, I'm just getting started on my thesis project now. A big sorta installation... "thingie."

ADAM: That's a good word, huh? "Thingie."

EVELYN: It is.... *(Points)* Anyway, *this* is only a pet peeve....

ADAM: Thesis? You're graduating....

EVELYN: In May.

ADAM: 'Kay. I'm only a Junior....

EVELYN: Huh. You seem older.

ADAM: Well, I am. I mean, older than twenty, anyhow...I worked for a couple years. Made money.

EVELYN: Not enough, though. Still got two jobs...

ADAM: Don't forget the school loans...

EVELYN: Right. So, basically, you're...fucked.

ADAM: Yep. But at least I'm educated, so I *comprehend* that I'm fucked....

(They stand there for a moment. ADAM checks his watch; EVELYN shakes her spray can.)

EVELYN: You're cute. I don't like the way you wear your hair....

ADAM: Thank you. I think....

EVELYN: No, you're definitely cute, but you shouldn't style it so much. Your hair. Just let it go...

ADAM: 'kay. I'll try that....

EVELYN: Your relief's late.

ADAM: Yeah. Typical...

EVELYN: So, do you have to stay at your station until they spell you, or...?

ADAM: No, at punch-out time, I'm supposed to get down there and do it. They can really be pricks about that....

EVELYN: You should go then....

ADAM: Right. Yeah, I...can I call you?

EVELYN: What do you wanna call me?

ADAM: Up. Just up, right now. Talk, maybe get crazy, take you to dinner...

EVELYN: Okay. Ahh...sure. *(Beat)* Do they allow you to do that here?

ADAM: What, eat dinner?

EVELYN: I meant hit on the patrons....

ADAM: ...ummm, no, they've got a pretty strict policy about that, too, actually. But...

EVELYN: ...ahh, the great equalizer. "But."

ADAM: Exactly. I'll take the risk....

EVELYN: ...good answer, grasshopper.

ADAM: Huh?

EVELYN: "Kung Fu." On TV. Remember when he was a kid? The old guy with the fakey contact lenses, and the....

ADAM: Oh, right...sure. "Grasshopper." I don't really watch much television....

EVELYN: My brothers loved that show. *(Beat)* So, do you want a number?

ADAM: Absolutely! *(Checks)* Damn, I don't have a pen.

EVELYN: Me either. *(Thinks)* Here...gimme the jacket.

ADAM: What?

EVELYN: Your jacket. Take it off for a second.

ADAM: Oh, that's, umm...it's supposed to be a "blazer."

EVELYN: What?

ADAM: It's my own...it's not part of the uniform. It's mine.

EVELYN: Good. Then you'll always have it on you...from the looks of it.

(ADAM follows her orders. EVELYN lays the coat open on the floor, looks around, then uncaps the paint and sprays a phone number inside.)

EVELYN: ...don't worry, it dries quick.

ADAM: Thanks. Okay, so, I'll...yeah. *(He glances back.)* Good luck with the...nice to meet you. Again.

EVELYN: You too.

(ADAM smiles at her, looks back again, walks off. EVELYN is left alone. She turns back to the statue and starts shaking her paint can. The little ball bearings inside rattle loudly.)

SCENE 2 - (The auditorium patio/Adam's apartment)

(ADAM standing with EVELYN. He looks a bit different, not as bulky and he's letting his hair go. Same jacket under his arm.)

EVELYN: ...no, seriously. You have.

ADAM: Yeah?

EVELYN: No question.

ADAM: I dunno. I think I still look....

EVELYN: You can definitely tell. You can.

ADAM: Really?

EVELYN: Definitely. Plus, the hair.../I bet your friends say something. Twenty bucks...

ADAM: Well, I'm glad..../I mean, I can't tell and so I figured...twenty bucks?

EVELYN: Yes. That's because you see "you" every day. Shower, getting dressed, that kind of thing. But...

ADAM: So do you.

EVELYN: I don't see you shower. Or getting dressed...

ADAM: No, I meant every day. So far, anyway, since we first went to....

EVELYN: I know, I'm kidding.

ADAM: Oh. Okay... *(Beat)* I'd like that, though. If you would....

EVELYN: Which?

ADAM: Both if you want. Either. Anything, any moment I can get with you...that's what I'd like.

EVELYN: Ask and you shall receive....

ADAM: So, I'm asking, then.

EVELYN: So you shall be receiving then....

(They share a brief kiss; he looks around self-consciously.)

ADAM: P D A. Public display of affection. I'm not used to that....

EVELYN: No? I don't mind....

ADAM: Really?

EVELYN: Nah, whose business is it? Ours, right? Kiss if we want to, make love in a bathroom stall...who cares?

ADAM: I'd start with the administration....

EVELYN: Yeah, but why should they? I mean...we're two adults, we....

ADAM: I think this is a bigger discussion than before Jenny and Phillip get here..../I mean, no, I'd love to have it with you, the discussion, and I agree, somewhat, but....

EVELYN: Whatever./I understand....

ADAM: Another time, we'll definitely discuss it.

EVELYN: Another time...I'd rather do it.

ADAM: Lemme go check the men's room... *(He laughs.)* ...you amaze me.

EVELYN: I'm glad. *(Beat)* And you amaze *me*, you do. Look at you!

ADAM: ...it's just a little jogging.

EVELYN: No, it's not. It's not just that...you're running, you're eating better, are you still lifting?

ADAM: Yeah...I mean, I didn't today, but....

EVELYN: That's okay.

ADAM: No, I'm gonna...so, yeah, alright, it's a whole routine thing. You're right....

EVELYN: Do you like doing it?

ADAM: Honestly...no. I totally hate it!

(They laugh.)

EVELYN: So why would you...?

ADAM: Because you suggested it. Which is kinda pathetic, but true....

EVELYN: You shouldn't do something you don't wanna do.

ADAM: Yeah, you should, why not? If it's for someone...I mean, I'm doing it for you.

EVELYN: It's a life change. Really...

ADAM: Right.

EVELYN: I gave you a couple ideas and you're changing your entire life. I'm very proud of you.

ADAM: Thank you... *(Cockney)* ...'enry 'iggins.

EVELYN: What's that?/Who's....

ADAM: Nothing./'S from a book. Play, actually.

EVELYN: Oh. Not the one we're seeing, though, is it?

ADAM: No, no, a musical...this is, umm, Medea.

EVELYN: Oh yeah, right. *(Smiles)* I read this as an undergrad, I *like* it....

ADAM: Ahh, you like Medea, huh? Should I be nervous?

EVELYN: No, not too much...I mean, unless we have kids.

ADAM: *(Laughing)* ...alright...

EVELYN: So...are you still keeping your journal? It really does help....

ADAM: Yes.

EVELYN: Will you let me read it?

ADAM: ...some time.

EVELYN: Good.

(They stand for a moment. EVELYN checks her watch.)

ADAM: And what about you?

EVELYN: What about me?

ADAM: That's what I mean...I don't know.

EVELYN: What?

ADAM: Nothing. I don't really know anything about you....

EVELYN: Yes, you do!

ADAM: I don't. Not really...

EVELYN: What's my name?

ADAM: Evelyn.

EVELYN: Where am I from?

ADAM: Illinois. Near Chicago?

EVELYN: Yes. How old am I?

ADAM: Ummm...twenty-five, maybe.

EVELYN: That's exactly right. Almost twenty-six. Sign?

ADAM: Gemini, I think....

EVELYN: The twins, yes.

ADAM: Does that mean you have a split personality?

EVELYN: No, it means I was born in June.

ADAM: Oh. *(Beat)* And you're, what, a sculptress, right? An artist...

EVELYN: Yep. Anything else you wanna know?

ADAM: Yes...everything!

EVELYN: So ask then...

ADAM: Well...why are you always asking me questions if it's no big deal.

EVELYN: Because you make me curious...I'm a curious person.

ADAM: I'm curious, too, though!

EVELYN: Like I said...so ask then.

ADAM: ...why do you like me?

EVELYN: What?

ADAM: Me...why would you like me? I'm not anything, I mean...and you're so....

EVELYN: Don't do that, okay? That's the only thing about you I don't like...what you see in yourself. Or don't see. Your insecurities. *(Beat)* Do you like me?

ADAM: Of course, you know I do....

EVELYN: Do I appear to like you? Hmm?

ADAM: Yes...it seems like it, yeah.

EVELYN: I do like you. Do you think I'm smart?

ADAM: I think you're amazing...and you have a *great* ass. Just thought you should know....

EVELYN: Not part of my query, but thank you.

ADAM: Welcome...

EVELYN: And do I seem to know my own mind? I mean, generally....

ADAM: No question.

EVELYN: So, don't you trust me, then, to know how I feel?

ADAM: Yeah. No, you're right....

EVELYN: Don't worry about *why* when *what* is right in front of you.

ADAM: Those're very wise words from someone with such a great ass....

EVELYN: (*Playfully*) Kiss me, grasshopper...

(They start to kiss again as A young couple approaches.)

JENNY: Ah, ah, ah...P D A.

PHILLIP: I don't think anybody wants to watch you kiss, Adam...we'll be eating later.

ADAM: Hey, Phillip, hello! Evelyn, this is Phillip, and his fiancée, Jenny....

("Hellos" all around.)

PHILLIP: So, we should grab our tickets, and.... (*Stopping to look*) Adam, what's up with you? D'you lost weight?

ADAM: ...a little, maybe.

JENNY: No, he cut his hair...or something. That's it, right?

ADAM: Umm, yeah. I mean, both, sort of.

PHILLIP: Huh. Okay, so, let's...come on.

(JENNY and PHILLIP lead the way. EVELYN stares at ADAM as they follow; he pulls a twenty out of his pocket and places it in her hand.)

SCENE 3 - (*The living room*)

(ADAM and EVELYN sitting on a couch. JENNY and PHILLIP in opposing chairs. Everyone holds a drink.)

ADAM: ...so, tell me this again, you're going to what?

PHILLIP: Underwater. We're going to get married underwater....

ADAM: You've gotta be kidding me!

PHILLIP: ...like those *Life* magazine photos you see or whatever./Seriously.

EVELYN: Huh./Is that, like, a "California" thing?

JENNY: No. We wanted to try something bold....

EVELYN: That oughta do it.

ADAM: This is crazy, really. And, so, if we want to attend we have to....

PHILLIP: ...get in the tank with us. You bet.

JENNY: No, honey, I thought we said....

PHILLIP: ...we haven't, okay, no, we haven't settled that part completely, but....

JENNY: My dad could never do that. I mean, my mom would try, she would, but dad....

PHILLIP: Maybe people can watch from the glass window things or whatever, but I'd prefer if they came in with us....

(He drains his glass, looking at ADAM)

ADAM: That is nuts....

EVELYN: Well, I applaud you. I think it's very....

PHILLIP: (*To EVELYN*) Yeah, well, don't expect my buddy here to follow in our footsteps. He's the least adventurous person I know....

EVELYN: Really?

PHILLIP: Absolutely! And the marriage thing? Uh-uh, not gonna happen, sorry. I don't know how many nights I listened to this guy say, "not me, man, I'm never getting hooked, no way, man..."

EVELYN: Is that right? Well, well...

ADAM: Listen, don't encourage him. My room-mate doesn't need any....

PHILLIP: ...former room-mate...

ADAM: ...more encouragement. (*Beat*) I'm gonna look stupid in one of those wet suits.

PHILLIP: Hey, let's not be a party-pooper here, my friend... (*Indicating JENNY*) ...this could've been yours.

(*ADAM laughs thinly; EVELYN doesn't understand.*)

ADAM: I know, I know....

PHILLIP: Right?

EVELYN: I'm lost. What's...?

PHILLIP: I stole Jenny away from Adam....

ADAM: Come on...

PHILLIP: I did! (*To JENNY*) Didn't I?

JENNY: No, you didn't, stop being.... (*To EVELYN*) Adam and I had a class together, but he never got up the nerve to ask me out.

EVELYN: Is that true?

ADAM: Something like that...

JENNY: Four months we sat next to each other— I'm borrowing his pen, like, all the time, hint-hint— and he's this total monk the whole semester...anyway, Phil picks him up from class one day, sees me, and we went to mini-golf that same night.

PHILLIP: I cannot tell a lie...I've got the moves, God help me.

ADAM: God help all of us....

(*A collective laugh*)

EVELYN: Well, like I said, I think it's great. It's really amazing, it is, to find anybody willing to take a risk today. To look a little silly or different or anything. Bravo! (*Toasts*) To people with balls...

(*They all toast, even PHILLIP with his empty glass, but he looks over at ADAM. ADAM blushes.*)

PHILLIP: "Balls," huh? Yep, that's my Jenny....

(*JENNY slaps him on the shoulder and blushes again.*)

EVELYN: You know what I mean. Guts. That kinda thing...

JENNY: Right. I got it.

PHILLIP: (*Toasting*) "To balls, long may they wave..."

(They all smile and “mock” drink again.)

PHILLIP: I'll tell you what took some balls, the museum thing, a few weeks back, with the...balls. You guys read about that?! I mean, Adam, of course you did, you were supposed to be *guarding* it, but—Evelyn, you hear about it?

JENNY: *(Whispering)* The penis...

EVELYN: *(Whispering)* Yes, I did. Why are we whispering?

PHILLIP: Because you don't say “penis” in Jenny's house. But we're at my place now, and so we sing it from the eaves! “Penis!! Pe-nis!!!”

ADAM: Okay, bar's closing, last call....

PHILLIP: No, seriously, do you believe that shit? Somebody with the gall to do that kinda bullshit on our campus?! That fucking burns me up....

EVELYN: I'm an artist, so I didn't....

ADAM: We should probably get, ummm....

PHILLIP: I mean, this isn't Berkeley! *(Beat)* What does that mean, anyway? “I'm an artist?”

EVELYN: It means nothing, really, just that I understand the impulse....

PHILLIP: You what?!

ADAM: Evelyn, maybe we should....

PHILLIP: No, wait Adam, I wanna hear... what “impulse?” It's called “vandalism.”

JENNY: Does anyone want dessert?

(PHILLIP holds up a hand to hush the group. He turns back to EVELYN.)

PHILLIP: No, hold on, this is rich. Go ahead...

EVELYN: Just that...I don't think it was just kids playing. I think it was a sort of statement, a kind of....

PHILLIP: ...a statement?

EVELYN: Yeah, I do....

JENNY: What kind of statement would that be? It was pornography....

EVELYN: No, it wasn't.

JENNY: Yes, it was....

EVELYN: Pornography is meant to titillate, to excite you. Did you see a picture of what happened?

PHILLIP: We did, yeah....

EVELYN: Does a penis excite you? I mean, just any ol' penis?

PHILLIP: You're funny. And that's not the point.

EVELYN: It's totally the point...how about you, Jenny, did you like what you saw? Did it get you hot?

PHILLIP: This is, like, uncalled for, okay? All she said was....

EVELYN: I know what she said, why don't you let her speak? *(To JENNY)* Did you wanna see anything else? Huh? Okay, then...all I'm saying is that, in my *opinion*, it wasn't pornography, it was a statement. Of course, that's the beauty of statements, like art, they're subjective. You and I can think completely different things and we can both be right...unless, and this seems quite probable, you just can't stand to lose an argument.

(Quiet for a moment from the group.)

PHILLIP: Wow. The postgraduate mind at work...

ADAM: I'll help you get dessert, Jenny, if you want to....

JENNY: ...I still don't think that makes it a statement. It's graffiti....

EVELYN: What do you mean, it would be a huge statement...especially for a town like this.

PHILLIP: Hey, some of us are from "a town like this," so maybe you should watch it.

EVELYN: Well, we've all gotta be from somewhere....

PHILLIP: What do you mean by that?

EVELYN: I mean, it's a little college town in the middle of nowhere and....

PHILLIP: One you chose, presumably....

EVELYN: No, it chose me, actually. *Full* scholarship. So, as I was saying....

PHILLIP: You've got a real winning way, you know that?

ADAM: Look, Phil, it's no big deal, let's just....

PHILLIP: Which "take back the night" rally did you find her at, Adam?

EVELYN: ...can I finish, please?! Jesus, you're really the obnoxious type, you know that? *(To ADAM)* How long did you have to stomach this guy?

(Everyone except EVELYN sort of freezes on that one.)

ADAM: Evelyn.

EVELYN: Anyhow, who knows what the person was saying by it, we don't, but I think it was a gesture. A kind of manifesto, if you will....

PHILLIP: (*Dryly*) I don't think a person's dick can be a manifesto. Uh-uh. You can write a manifesto on your thing, but your thing can't be one...I'm sure I read that somewhere.

EVELYN: See? You're just trying to be....

PHILLIP: I'm not trying to be anything! Who the hell do you think you are, a few double dates and telling me anything about who I am? Un-fucking-believable!

JENNY: This is getting a little, ahh....

PHILLIP: ...Adam, you can really pick 'em. Wow, man!

ADAM: Look, it's not, let's just forget the....

EVELYN: You're not gonna take his side in this, are you?

ADAM: I'm not taking sides, I'm trying to get outta here with just a touch of dignity, okay? Jesus...

JENNY: I've got a test tomorrow, anyway....

PHILLIP: "Statement," she says!

EVELYN: Shut the fuck up, alright? Just fuck right off...how would you know? I think she was making one, so that's my opinion....

ADAM: Jenny, thanks for everything. Phillip, I'll call ya, or whatever, but we're gonna....

PHILLIP: Yeah? How do you know it was a girl?

EVELYN: ...I don't. I didn't say it was a woman.

PHILLIP: Girl, woman, whatever. You said "she," how do you know that?

EVELYN: I don't, I just said. It's a guess. What it was, where it was placed. An *educated* guess...

PHILLIP: You are not...she's not trying to take a poke at my being an undergrad, is she? Adam, tell me she didn't just....

JENNY: Can we stop, now, please?! You guys...

ADAM: Evelyn, let's go...

PHILLIP: Hey, artiste...how'd you know it was a woman who painted the cock, huh? Very, very suspicious there...

EVELYN: You are such a prick, man, how do you go on, day after day? (*To ADAM*) Let's go...

(*She rises, snatches up her things and moves towards the door*)

Adam? Are you coming?

ADAM: I'm...yeah, but, just go. I'll meet you downstairs, I just wanna...go ahead.

EVELYN: 'kay. (*To JENNY*) You're very sweet. Good luck...

(She heads for the door and exits.)

PHILLIP: “Good luck.” Hey, fuck you! *(To ADAM)* Where in hell did you meet that bitch?!/What’d she do, give you a haircut and a blow job and now you’re her puppy?!!/You don’t have to go....

ADAM: ...at the museum./No, I’m not her.... *(To JENNY)* The wedding sounds great. Really...it sounds...yeah.

(He wanders off. PHILLIP and JENNY sit in silence.)

PHILLIP: ...what?

SCENE 4 - (*The bedroom*)

(An explosion of color and patterns. An enormous bed in the middle of it all. Groovy lighting.)

(ADAM and EVELYN in bed. Holding each other, staring off. A video camera on a tripod nearby)

EVELYN: Nice.

ADAM: Very. Yes.

EVELYN: Our bodies are beginning to understand one another....

ADAM: You're right, I mean....

EVELYN: Getting a rhythm. And less inhibited.

ADAM: Yep.

(He leans over and whispers something in her ear. A huge smile across her face. She turns and whispers back to him. They laugh and kiss for a moment. They hold one another.)

EVELYN: *(Quietly)* Were you always like this before? So...you know....

ADAM: ...shy? Just about the fact that no one would sleep with me. That's all.

EVELYN: Come on...

ADAM: Seriously. You're only, like, I dunno, the third person I've ever....

EVELYN: ...no...

ADAM: Yes, I mean it. And they were both young. I mean, I was too, I wasn't, like, hanging out at a *day care* or anything, but...it was during high school mostly. So...you're sort of in uncharted waters here.

EVELYN: I don't wanna blow your cover but... I could kinda tell.

ADAM: *(Smiling)* Yeah? Well, that's okay....

EVELYN: And nobody here at school?

ADAM: Nothing serious. Dates. Some close calls. But not anyone...you know.

EVELYN: ...like Jenny.

ADAM: No.

EVELYN: You sorry you didn't ask her out? I mean, if I wasn't in the equation....

ADAM: Not really. We just never got the right... whatever. I sorta blew that one. Anyway, it's kind of weird talking about....

EVELYN: It's okay. That's nice to see, every so often. Someone gallant...

ADAM: Which is medieval for “loser”... *(Beat)* I wanna tell you something—and this is not because we’ve been sleeping together or because you mentioned another girl, it’s not—I can’t stop thinking about you. I can’t. I mean, it’s not like a stalker situation...yet...but I’m finding myself hanging out by your classes. Following you...

EVELYN: I’ve noticed....

ADAM: I figured, yeah. And taking my jacket off, like, thirty times a day and looking at your number. Staring at it. Wondering if you’re looking at my number. And writing your name on anything! All over my books. In my *food*. Seriously, tracing your name in whatever I’m eating. I’m so whipped...

you are dangerously close to owning me.

EVELYN: Wow...

ADAM: I just signed my relationship death warrant, didn’t I?/What a dork...

EVELYN: ...no, it’s sweet!/It is!! *(She kisses him.)* Were you nervous earlier? I mean, about us with the video?

ADAM: Nah. Not really. *(Beat)* A bit...

EVELYN: Sure?

ADAM: Yeah. It’s just...let’s not watch it, okay? Do we have to do that?

EVELYN: Not if you don’t want to....

ADAM: Good. I don’t think I could get into that, actually....

EVELYN: Why not? It’d be fun....

ADAM: I don’t really need to see myself doing that. Doing...stuff.

EVELYN: See, I’m totally different. I think everyone should see themselves doing it, and their friends should see it, too.

ADAM: And that’s why the tape’s gonna stay at my place....

(She smiles at this, kissing him.)

EVELYN: Don’t be so frightened of everything.

ADAM: I’m not. Not frightened, anyway. I just don’t think that’s a thing other people need to see. Ever. My ass...

EVELYN: People like who...Phillip?

ADAM: No, that’s fine, you can show it to him.... *(Beat)* Are you nuts?!

EVELYN: Why is he your friend?

ADAM: Do you really wanna go over that...?

EVELYN: I just don’t get it.

ADAM: What’s to get? We were room-mates, we occasionally see each other, have a drink....

EVELYN: I just don’t think you need that kind of person in your life. No one does.

ADAM: (*Mock-serious*) ...it may be a touch early to start dictating who my friends are.

EVELYN: (*With charm*) Yeah...I s'pose.

ADAM: Geez, he really got under your skin, didn't he?

EVELYN: Under. Over. Around. I hate that kind of guy....

ADAM: What kind?

EVELYN: That kind. Whatever he is, that's what I hate....

ADAM: I'll let him know.

EVELYN: No, God, no, don't give him the satisfaction. And he'd take it, too, believe me....

ADAM: Nah, maybe it'd help him, you know, be better...or something.

EVELYN: The only thing that would help him is a fucking knife through his throat....

(*They grow quiet for a moment. ADAM studies EVELYN.*)

ADAM: Okay, I'm glad I don't have a pet rabbit or anything right now....

EVELYN: (*Laughing*) You know what I mean.

ADAM: Ummmm, no, not really.

EVELYN: I've just been around his type, that's all. And I don't like 'em.

ADAM: Yeah, I got that part....

EVELYN: No big deal.

ADAM: Right, no, it was the "knife through the throat" part that was the big deal, I thought....

EVELYN: Oh, that's just an expression.

ADAM: ...from where, Transylvania?

(*She kisses him.*)

EVELYN: No...from the "Scorned Girl's Handbook."

ADAM: Ahhh. Right...page 666.

EVELYN: (*Smiling*) You've been peeking. You know what happens to peekers, don't you? I'll show you...but you have to do me a favor.

ADAM: What's that?

(*She starts to slip under the covers.*)

EVELYN: ...just smile. Smile into the camera. For as long as you can...

SCENE 7 - (The lawn)

(PHILLIP and ADAM sitting on their jackets between classes, talking. PHILLIP has a pair of sunglasses perched on his head. ADAM has a bandage across his nose.)

PHILLIP: ...I'm serious, it looks good.

ADAM: Phil, I look like a hockey player....

PHILLIP: Yeah, but a distinguished one.

(They chuckle.)

PHILLIP: What'd you do, anyway?

ADAM: ...I fell.

PHILLIP: Come on...

ADAM: Seriously, I did....

PHILLIP: You sound like a battered wife. "I fell...."

ADAM: That's not funny.

PHILLIP: Yeah, it is...it's very funny. I mean, it's not that funny that wives get beat up, but the fact that you look like one, that I find hilarious....

ADAM: Well, anyway, that's what happened. I tripped, I fell...no big deal.

PHILLIP: So, you don't wanna tell me then, right?

ADAM: Tell you what?!

PHILLIP: What happened to your...

ADAM: I told you. I tripped going up the...and hit the edge of the....

PHILLIP: Yeah, it's the "edge of" that I'm a little hazy on here....

ADAM: Edge of the knob. My door knob.

PHILLIP: She clocked you one, didn't she?

ADAM: Who?

PHILLIP: "Who?" The artist, formerly known as Evelyn....

ADAM: Are you nuts?

PHILLIP: Well, I've gotta hand it to her, she certainly made a "statement"....

ADAM: You are such an idiot....

PHILLIP: You really tripped? Truthfully...

ADAM: Yes.

PHILLIP: ...huh. Okay.

ADAM: Why do you say that? "Huh." You don't believe me?

PHILLIP: No, I just...nothing.

ADAM: What? Don't do that, come on now. What?

PHILLIP: It's no big.... *(Beat)* I saw your girlfriend the other day, maybe, what, last Thursday? You weren't in class, and I said to her, I asked her if you were okay, that's all....

ADAM: Yeah, so?

PHILLIP: And she said "yes," but you were recovering from an operation or something....

ADAM: What?!

PHILLIP: That what I said, "he didn't tell me about anything," and she said it wasn't really an operation *per se*, just some thing you had done. A procedure. And that was it...so I just thought....

ADAM: No, it's not....

PHILLIP: Hey, you don't have to tell me, we're not on intimate terms or anything....

ADAM: I hurt it. Really...

PHILLIP: Whatever.

ADAM: No, not "whatever." Phil...I did. I hit it and, you know...I banged it pretty bad at home and so I had the doctor look at it. But he didn't...*operate* or anything. The bandage is from that. The door.

PHILLIP: After you tripped on the stairs...yeah, you told me.

ADAM: She must've just gotten confused.

PHILLIP: Maybe. That doesn't seem to happen to her very often, though...she's pretty sharp.

ADAM: No, she is...I'm sure it's just the way I explained it. I mean, to her....

PHILLIP: Right.

ADAM: ...and where did you see her?

PHILLIP: Evelyn? I don't know...Starbucks or somewhere. The mall, maybe.

ADAM: She doesn't drink coffee.

PHILLIP: So, it was downtown then, Record City, I think.... *(Beat)* What, you worried I'm gonna steal her? Believe me...

ADAM: No, God...don't be so... *(Touches nose)* Anyway, it's gonna be fine....

PHILLIP: Well, that's good to hear.

ADAM: Yep.

PHILLIP: *(Beat)* And you'd tell me if there was anything seriously wrong?

ADAM: ...of course! Hey, what's up?

PHILLIP: I mean, we're friends, right? You'd come to me....

ADAM: ...about what? *(Beat)* Phil, what's...?

PHILLIP: Jenny told me.

ADAM: What?

(ADAM looks at his friend. For the first time, PHILLIP seems less than in control.)

PHILLIP: She kissed you.

ADAM: Oh.

PHILLIP: She felt shitty, I guess. I could tell for, like, a week that something was going on and finally she told me about it. How you guys met and talked about us—why do girls always have to *talk* about everything?—and later she leaned over and kissed you. That's what she told me.

ADAM: She did...I mean, she did do that but it was nothing.

PHILLIP: Hey, it wasn't nothing, she's a good kisser. Hell of a kisser.

ADAM: I don't mean "nothing," but it meant nothing. It didn't hold any meaning for us...it just happened.

PHILLIP: Okay. So, you can speak for her, then?

ADAM: For me...it didn't for me. It was just a... that's all she said?

PHILLIP: Don't tell me there's more....

ADAM: No, God, not at all...I just....

PHILLIP: It's alright, I'd been acting weird lately, this whole marriage idea is just...freaky...so, it's my fault.

ADAM: Right...

PHILLIP: I mean, who gets married at *twenty-four* these days? Right? It's not the Middle Ages, for Chrissakes.... *(Beat)* I just feel bad...you know, for her.

ADAM: Why?

PHILLIP: Kissing you...that's hideous! It's what those new-age dumbshits would call "a desperate cry for help"....

(They laugh, catching each other's eye.)

ADAM: Sorry...

PHILLIP: 'S alright. It's better than me having to kiss you....

ADAM: Good point.

PHILLIP: No tongue, right?

ADAM: Jesus...

(PHILLIP looks at his watch.)

PHILLIP: Well, I got a three-ten. “International Cinema” or some shit.

ADAM: Yeah?

PHILLIP: I guess...it’s an elective, I just show up for the tests. You?

ADAM: Nah...I’m free. Gonna go work out.

PHILLIP: You and the...what is going on with the “metamorphosis” thing here?
You’re like Frankenstein....

ADAM: You mean, Frankenstein’s monster. Frankenstein was the doctor....

PHILLIP: Ahh, don’t be such an English Lit prick...

ADAM: I am an English Lit prick.

PHILLIP: I know, but you don’t have to sound like one, do you? Doctor, monster, whatever! What’s up with that?

ADAM: Nothing. It feels good.

PHILLIP: How much weight have you lost?

ADAM: Not that much, maybe ten pounds or...

PHILLIP: I’d say more like fifteen.

ADAM: Yeah, maybe.

PHILLIP: And the hair thing going, no glasses now....

ADAM: It’s just a few little....

PHILLIP: Hey, it’s the “new you.” Plus, the nails. Jenny told me that, which is the one thing that I just cannot believe!

ADAM: It’s a life change....

PHILLIP: Please, don’t make me throw up with the Oprah-talk, alright? I’m trying to compliment you here....

ADAM: ...thanks.

PHILLIP: I used to find blood on our *phone*, okay, so it’s not just this casual thing, quitting....

ADAM: I know. I know that....

PHILLIP: Alright, then. (*Beat*) No, you look good. I can see why she kissed you...hell, I might even kiss you, with a few drinks in me.

ADAM: (*Laughing*) I’ll run home and hide the liquor....

PHILLIP: Please, I’ll help you! (*Beat*) And nothing else happened, right, I mean, between you and Jenny?

(*ADAM stops cold. Walked right into a trap.*)

ADAM: ...what?

PHILLIP: I’m just asking.

ADAM: Phil...

PHILLIP: Not really looking for a speech or anything. Just an answer. She said “no,” just so you don’t think I’m laying a trap here or whatever....

ADAM: I don’t.

PHILLIP: ...nobody saw you on campus or anything. A lifeguard out by the dunes, you know, so....

ADAM: ...what’s that supposed to mean?

PHILLIP: I’m just *saying*, I’ll believe you, whatever you tell me. I’ve got no witnesses. So...

ADAM: Nothing happened, Phil. Truthfully.

PHILLIP: ...that’s not what she said.

(ADAM freezes but doesn’t falter.)

ADAM: That’s not true.

PHILLIP: You sure?

ADAM: Yes.

PHILLIP: You’re right, it’s not true. Hey, a man’s gotta try....

ADAM: Uh-huh...

PHILLIP: Not that I want out of this or anything. I love scuba-diving....

ADAM: Of course. As we all do....

PHILLIP: Exactly. I’m just not sure I wanna share my air tank with the same person the rest of my life....

(ADAM says nothing, just smiles.)

PHILLIP: ...but that’s my problem. *(Beat)* I gotta get to class....

ADAM: Alright. Take care.

PHILLIP: Sorry for the, you know, crazy shit.

ADAM: It’s okay....

PHILLIP: ...don’t kiss my girlfriend any more, alright?

ADAM: You got it.

PHILLIP: So long, Romeo!

ADAM: *(Pulling on a coat)* Knock it off!

(PHILLIP starts off but stops dead. He turns back and studies ADAM.)

PHILLIP: ...where’s your jacket?

ADAM: What?

PHILLIP: Okay, this is too much. The cord jacket, the lumberjacky-looking thing...

ADAM: I dunno...anyway, it's not a jacket, it's a blazer.

PHILLIP: Uh-huh. And this, umm, Tommy Hilfiger-ish job, where'd you come up with that?

ADAM: ...the mall. I bought it.

PHILLIP: *You* bought some clothes? You, like, went out to the mall on your bike and actually....

ADAM: No, Evelyn drove me. So? What's the big...?

PHILLIP: The deal is this...you've had that frumpy-looking fucker for three years, probably more, and I've never seen you out of it. *Ever*. Middle of California, the dead of *summer*, whatever, you've got that coat on. And now you're just like, "Hey, whatever, (*Yawns*) yeah, I bought the ol' stars and stripes here with Evelyn." That's like a sailing slicker!

ADAM: It's their yachtsman line....

PHILLIP: I am gonna puke here, I swear to God! I did not just hear you use the word "yachtsman"....

ADAM: Hey, she likes it.... (*Opens jacket*) It's reversible

PHILLIP: Well, isn't that just neat? And peachy keen and whatever other *Little House On The Prairie* shit you wanna spout...what I wanna know is, do you like it?

ADAM: ...it's okay.

PHILLIP: Not what I said. I asked, "do-you-like-it?"

ADAM: It's fine. It's a coat....

PHILLIP: And lemme ask you...did you get to keep the cord job or did she make you toss it?

ADAM: ...who cares? This is...I threw it out, okay? Goodwill, actually.

PHILLIP: "Goodwill, actually."

ADAM: It's really no big thing....

PHILLIP: Dude, don't just say "no big thing." I begged you to throw out the "blazer" our Freshman year, I mean, you've lost *both* of us a lot of dates with that thing on! You've had it since, like, birth, okay, so do me a little favor and let's not pretend that the jacket and the, ahh, weight and the Jon Bon Jovi hair are no big deal. Because when it comes to routine, you used to be like Mister goddamn *Rogers*!

ADAM: Phil, it's a fucking jacket so just lay off. Go to class...

PHILLIP: Uh-huh. Fine...

ADAM: Fine.

PHILLIP: I just hope next time we pass each other I recognize who the hell you are....

ADAM: Well, if not, you and Evelyn can always head over to Record City and have a chat....

PHILLIP: Hey, I wouldn't get too deep into the moral issues during this particular conversation...okay, Romeo? I may have a big fucking mouth, but at least I keep it to myself....

(They stare at each other, a nearly visible wall going up between them. ADAM blinks first and walks off. PHILLIP watches him go.)

PHILLIP: So long, matey!

SCENE 9 - (The auditorium)

EVELYN: Good evening. Thank you for coming out tonight—it's the middle of finals and I'm sure this is not how most of you would choose to spend your time away from campus...*on campus*. So, I promise to make this presentation as quick and painless as possible and get you back home as swiftly as I can.

The accompanying visual portion of this graduate thesis project is currently under review but will hopefully be available in the exhibition gallery down the hall for your perusal next week, so if you don't stay tonight for punch and cookies, ummm, please stop by and take a look at your convenience. *(Smiles)* Okay, that's the boring stuff....
(She turns over a note card.)

My task here tonight is to unveil my semester's work, explain it and then smile and shake hands, leaving a few of you to examine it, grade it, etc. In essence, be at your mercy. Here at "Mercy." *(Laughs)* Which is fine, since I realize I have been my entire academic life—at someone's mercy, that is— So be it...that's the system and one person can't change it...but perhaps they can make you question that system and your values just a little bit. *(Looks over cards)* Blah-blah-blah...
(She starts to move but steps back into the light, as if she's forgotten something.)

Oh, I almost forgot...and this is fairly personal, probably shouldn't even do it but it really is the capper to my time here at Mercy, so please indulge me. *(Beat)* I was given an engagement ring two days ago and I haven't answered the guy yet...So I wanted to do it this evening. Here goes. This is a beautiful stone and an amazing gesture on your part, for many reasons. By the time I'm through here, I promise that you'll have your answer....

(She shows the ring off to the audience.)

My graduate advisor gave me this advice five months ago..."Strive to make art, but change the world." Pretty wise words, I thought, at the time, and so, being a good little student, that's what I set out to do. *(She appears almost nervous, but not quite. She looks at the audience for a moment.)* With that in mind, I present to you this, my newest work. It is a *human* sculpture on which I've worked these past eighteen weeks, and of whom I'm very proud.

I cannot legally name him tonight as he hasn't yet signed a waiver for the various items on display in the visual portion, but it's a small college, and a smaller town, (*Laughs*) so you've got a pretty decent chance at guessing who it is. In fact, I've done all I could to be as visible as possible with him this year—I'm more of a stay-at-home person myself— The piece itself is untitled since I think, I hope, that it will mean something different to each of you and, frankly, anyone who sees it.

(She uncovers a large photograph from a nearby easel. The eyes have been blurred but it is undeniably the "old" ADAM.)

This is a "before" picture that I had a classmate take of us near the Pizza Hut out by the highway. That was our first official encounter after he asked me out—at his place of work, a big no-no, or so I was told—and it was here that I coaxed him into eating his first vegetarian meal.

(JENNY is suddenly up and storms off toward an exit, crumpling up her program and throwing it as she goes. EVELYN waits, smiling, then continues.)

EVELYN: Anyway, he told me that for him, it was a huge deal and it does mark the beginning of my systematic makeover, or "sculpting," if you will, of my two very pliable materials of choice: the human flesh and the human will. (*Beat*) I first spotted my chosen base material... Sorry, but a lawyer actually told me I had to say that, "base material"...

(She scans the audience.)

EVELYN:

(only if the actual audience is quiet say these 2 lines) Still with me? You're very quiet...okay.

The exhibit itself will give you many first-hand examples of my efforts, some hands-on such as video tapes or sound recordings of our conversations and others more scientific in nature, as in growth charts, X-rays and accompanying data.

As you can see from this photo, however, the hair, the glasses, the excessive amount of weight, offered a number of physical areas that made him unique and perfect for this project.

A short list of alterations I've induced would include eating better and losing weight—some twenty-five pounds or more— the purchase of contact lenses, a complete change in hairstyles and significant wardrobe alterations as well. He even tattooed his body for me, without asking...in a highly questionable place.

But this, I'm afraid, was not done out of love or caring or concern...this was a simple matter of can I instill "X" amount of change in this creature, using only manipulation as my palette knife? I made sure that nothing was ever forced during our sessions or "sittings" together—I can't really say they were dates, not on my part, although the allusion of "dating" was imperative—and that his free will was always at the forefront of each decision. I made suggestions, created the illusion of interest and desire, but never said, "You must do this." Not once. Any questions yet?

(She surveys her audience again.)

EVELYN: Ummmm...you may be asking yourselves, "Well, did she at least tell him?" Of course not, no, I couldn't. Not until tonight, or he really wouldn't be a piece of art. He would be a jilted lover, a spurned fiancé. But he is more than that...he's my creation.

Now, it'll be easy for many of you to condemn my actions as harsh, inhumane or just unrealistic as you drive or walk home tonight, but how many here can say that they have never looked at their significant other and/or a business associate and said, "They're perfect, they're great, except for just *one* thing..." Well, I too have taken my base materials and honed them into something new, something unique and, in the eyes and standards of society, something arguably improved.

But, with the artist's ruthless pursuit of truth and historical disregard for rule and law...I've gone a step further. I found that, with the right coaxing of my material—yes, "coaxing" often of a sexual nature, I'll admit—I could hone the inside of my sculpture as well as the surface. I found myself suddenly creating strong moral ambiguity where I could detect only the slightest traces before, often in direct proportion to the amount of external change.

This means, as my subject became handsomer and firmer and more confident, his actions became more and more, *questionable*. Against medical advice, he had work done to his face, cosmetic surgery at age twenty-two, and insisted to those around

him that he had merely fallen down. He also started to deceive his friends and myself with greater abandon during this period while showing increased interest in other women.

Indeed, he had relations with his best friend's fiancée and continues to harbor details from us about the incident to this day. Moreover, he was willing to give those friends up when asked, walk away from them without any further contact, after said encounter, leading me to an assumption of further wrong-doing with the young woman in question. And, as stated Earlier...

(PHILLIP now stands, walking slowly up an aisle and looking right at ADAM.)

PHILLIP: ...THIS IS FUCKED.

(When he is gone, EVELYN plows onward.)

EVELYN: ...these universal corrections culminated in an offer of marriage to me, this coming from a confirmed, albeit young, bachelor. I call this act "morally questionable" because it seems to be motivated, in my mind at least, as much out of guilt as genuine feelings for me. He has then, as I see it, been utterly and totally refashioned as a person. *(Beat)* As my grandfather used to say, "He's a real piece of work..."

(She unveils a large "after" photo for all to see.)

And yet open any fashion magazine, turn on any television program and the world will tell you...he's only gotten more interesting, more desirable, more normal. In a word, *better*. He is a living, breathing example of our obsession with the surface of things, the shape of them. *(Indicating "after" photo)* Not bad, huh? And ladies, he is available.

(To ADAM) This was a startling and unexpected gesture, but obviously, I can't accept.... *(She takes off the ring and places it on an easel.)*

You can examine the stone and setting further when it's placed in the exhibit. *(Beat)* As for me, I have no regrets or feelings of remorse for my actions, the manufactured emotions...none of it. I have always stood by the single and simple conceit that I am an artist. Only that. I follow in a long tradition of artists who believe that there is no such concept as religion, or government, community or even family. There is only art. Art that must be created. Whatever the cost.

(ADAM can stand it no longer.)

EVELYN: Now, you may have a different opinion, *feel* differently, I welcome that. Difference is good. Great. Vital, even. Only difference is suspect. Only to indifference do I say, “Fuck you”.

(EVELYN softly lifts both middle fingers to her audience, making sure she points them at everyone watching.)

EVELYN: With that in mind, I present you with my untitled sculpture and supporting materials tonight. Thank you.

(She takes a short bow and steps out of the light.)

SCENE 10 - (The exhibition gallery)

(EVELYN standing all alone, punch in one hand, cookie in the other. After a moment, she takes a nibble. She crosses to a box of photos and browses. ADAM enters and stares at her.)

ADAM: ...not a big “modern art” crowd, I guess, huh?

EVELYN: Hey. *(Beat)* Glad you stopped by...

ADAM: Yeah, well, I didn’t really have anything to do...plus, I can’t show my face in the streets, so it seemed logical.

EVELYN: Look, Adam...

ADAM: Please don’t “Look, Adam” me now, okay, or I might not make it through this.... *(Beat)* Just refer to me as “it” or “untitled,” it’ll help me keep some perspective here....

(He wanders over and pours some punch. Stuffs a few cookies in his pocket. Shoves three in his mouth and chews them down.)

...that’s gonna shoot some piece of data all to shit, isn’t it?

EVELYN: Doesn’t matter now, do what you want...you’re finished.

ADAM: “You’re finished.” Wow. *(Considers)* Most people just say, “Hey, sorry, can’t marry you.” And they say it in private....

EVELYN: ...yeah, that might’ve been a bit too far.

ADAM: Oh shit, Evelyn, you are so beyond “far” that you’re in danger of hitting Uranus. And I mean the planet....

EVELYN: *(Smiling)* See, you’re still funny....

ADAM: Just stop, alright? I was never funny, or good- looking or clever. I was nothing until you started dicking around with me. I admit it. No-thing. But you know what? I was absolutely fine with that....

EVELYN: I know this is a lot for you to take in and everything....

ADAM: Uh-huh...I got a little Gregor Samsa thing going right now, so....

EVELYN: I don’t get that....

ADAM: Doesn’t matter. I do...I get it.

(A moment of dead silence.)

EVELYN: ...listen, I know my work relied on not telling you what was going on, but I....

ADAM: Here in a “small town” we just call it lying....

EVELYN: I did lie to you, yes....

ADAM: Yeah, just a little. *(Beat)* “I’m a very straightforward person...”

EVELYN: I had to say that. Sorry.

ADAM: You’re sorry? Well, that’s good...I figured I was gonna have to really work to get that one out of you.

EVELYN: *I’m* not sorry. I mean, not for what I’ve done. I just feel bad that you’re so upset....

ADAM: Oh, I see....

EVELYN: I even thought maybe you could handle it. I did, really...otherwise I wouldn’t have invited you tonight.

ADAM: Yeah, just me and two hundred of my closest friends.

EVELYN: Adam, you don’t have any friends. *(Beat)* You gave up the only ones I’ve known you to have. Gave ‘em up pretty easily...

(ADAM shivers at this one; she’s turned out to be a cool little number.)

ADAM: Geez...don’t hold back at all, please. Call it exactly how you see it.

EVELYN: I just want to keep it as truthful as possible.

ADAM: *(Laughing)* That’ll be different....

EVELYN: ...you’re so angry....

ADAM: Well, you know, Evelyn, what do you want me to say?! You messed with my life and you put it under fucking glass...that might make anyone a touch cross.

EVELYN: What’d I do wrong? *(Beat)* Seriously, tell me...

ADAM: Screw you...

EVELYN: You have screwed me. A lot. You wanna watch it? There’s a cassette over there somewhere.

ADAM: You are seriously fucked up. I mean it....

EVELYN: Yeah...what was so bad? I wanna know, tell me...from your perspective.

ADAM: I’m not gonna give you a last little thrill. Fuck that.

EVELYN: Listen to your mouth, Adam...you never used to talk like that.

ADAM: You’re gonna take credit for that, too, huh?

EVELYN: Nope, you picked that up all on your own. Cute guys always have potty mouths. They think it makes ‘em cuter....

ADAM: Yeah, well, tell me how “cute” this one is, then...fuck you, you heartless cunt.

EVELYN: So, tell me then. Go ahead, you feel that way about me, you can tell me what I did wrong. *If* I did something wrong....

ADAM: You don't see this as wrong?!

EVELYN: I said, you tell me. I wanna know what you think I did....

(He stops for a moment, taking a deep breath. Not really wanting to engage)

ADAM: You honestly have no concept here....

EVELYN: The exercising? Or was it the new clothes that really bugged you?

ADAM: That is not the....

EVELYN: Everything I did made you a more desirable person, Adam. People began to notice you...take interest in you. I watched them....

ADAM: Well, lucky me. I got to be part of your installation "thingie."

EVELYN: You *are* my installation thingie.... *(Beat)* Look, if you hadn't been here tonight, hadn't heard all this stuff...wouldn't you still be happy? Waiting at home for me, hoping this went well, wanting to make love....

ADAM: That's not the point....

EVELYN: Yes, it is! It's the *total* point. All that stuff we did was real for you, therefore it was real. It wasn't for me, therefore it wasn't. It's all subjective, Adam. Everything.

ADAM: Not love. Not cruelty.

EVELYN: Of course they are....

ADAM: *(Reaching)* I'll tell you something "real," I should sue your ass.

EVELYN: You could...I did take that risk.

ADAM: That's right, you did, and you're crazy if you think I'm gonna let you put all this shit on display. Our time together. *(Wanders about)* Oh, but you'd love that, wouldn't you? If I got a lawyer. Then we could fight this out in public, all the way to the Supreme Court.

EVELYN: Or higher...Jerry Springer. *(Beat)* You should be proud of this...most of it.

(Looking about, he spots his old cord blazer sticking out of a box. Surprised, he pulls it free and stares at it.)

ADAM: What's this doing here?

EVELYN: It was only four bucks at the Goodwill....

ADAM: ...why would you buy that?

EVELYN: Just so I'd have it.

ADAM: What?

EVELYN: ...all of you.

(He scans the room, then throws his hands up. Suddenly, ADAM pulls off his new coat and tosses it onto the floor.)

ADAM: ...fine.

EVELYN: What?

ADAM: It's fine, forget it....

EVELYN: What is?

ADAM: What the hell...it can't get any worse. You get off on showing people my old socks and scuzzy sheets, go for it....

EVELYN: I don't "get off" on it....

ADAM: My "Fruit of the Looms" mean that much to you, have a field day....

EVELYN: ...Adam, this is my work. *(Beat)* I'll give back whatever you want, soon as I get my grade.

ADAM: Whatever...

EVELYN: I will.

ADAM: The ring'd be nice. It was my grandma's.

EVELYN: I'll take care of it.

ADAM: Thanks. Good...

EVELYN: ...hard feelings?

ADAM: Me? Nah...we had some fun, right?

EVELYN: Yeah.

ADAM: But, hey, that's subjective.

EVELYN: Exactly.

ADAM: Then / had some fun, fell in love and all that... and you got yourself a grade and a column inch or two in the school paper. Congrats. Seriously...but do me a favor, don't fool yourself and think that this is "art." 'kay? It's a sick fucking joke, but it is not "art."

EVELYN: Is that right?

ADAM: Pretty much, yeah. *(Beat)* You know, when Picasso took a shit, he didn't call it a "sculpture." He knew the difference. That's what made him *Picasso*. And if I'm wrong about that, I mean, if I totally miss the point here and somehow puking up your own little shitty neuroses all over people's laps is actually Art, then you oughta at least realize there's a price to it all...you know? Somebody pays for your two minutes on C N N. Someone always pays for people like you. And if you don't get that, if you can't see at least *that* much...then you're about two inches away from using babies to make lamp shades and calling it "furniture." *(Beat)* I guess I'm done....

EVELYN: Wow. Okay...so, you're saying I should be a "better person." Is that it?

ADAM: That's the nutshell, yeah.

EVELYN: Better like...*you*?

ADAM: No. Just better... *(Beat)* Anybody can be provocative, or shocking. Stand up in class and take a piss, paint yourself blue and run naked through a church screaming out the names of people you've slept with. Is that Art, or did you just forget to take your meds? *(Beat)* It doesn't matter if you call it "Art" if you have nothing to say. And you don't. You just need attention....

EVELYN: Well, we'll just have to agree to disagree, then, won't we?

ADAM: Yes, we will. We will definitely do that. *(Beat)* Don't forget what Oscar Wilde said....

EVELYN: He always had something to say, didn't he?

ADAM: Yeah..."All art is quite useless." He said that.

EVELYN: Huh. I thought you were gonna go with "Insincerity and treachery somehow seem inseparable from the artistic temperament." That's a good one, too....

ADAM: It is, yeah. Damn, wish I'd said that.

EVELYN: Don't worry about it...look how he ended up.

ADAM: Yep...alone, penniless and in prison. Everything I wish for you.... *(Beat)* Tell me, though. One thing.

EVELYN: Yes?

ADAM: Was any of it true?

EVELYN: What do you mean?

ADAM: Not the things we did, or the kind words or whatever...but any of it?

EVELYN: ...no. Not really.

ADAM: I mean about you. The nose-job or Lake Forest. One thing you ever said to me? Are you twenty-five?

EVELYN: Twenty-two. Just...I skipped two grades.

ADAM: Okay... *(Beat)* And the scars are....

EVELYN: Those were a different project.

ADAM: Got it. I got it...Gemini at least?

EVELYN: No, Pisces. Sorry.

ADAM: Don't be. Hey, it's...*Art*.

EVELYN: ...I should probably get going. I think the Dean wants "a word" with me. *(Ricky Ricardo voice)* "I got some 'splaining to do."

ADAM: What's that from?

EVELYN: Nothing. *I Love Lucy*.

ADAM: Ahh, T V. That other great art form....

EVELYN: Uh-huh. You coming?

ADAM: Nah, not yet... *(Holds up hands)* Don't worry, I'm not gonna do anything to your stuff. No spray paint. I just....

EVELYN: I understand. Go ahead.

ADAM: Thanks...

EVELYN: The door locks if you just close it.

ADAM: Great.

(EVELYN smiles at him once more, but says nothing. What's to say? She heads for the door but stops.)

EVELYN: ...that one time.

ADAM: Huh?

EVELYN: In my bed, one night, when you leaned over and whispered in my ear...remember?

ADAM: 'Course. I remember everything about us.

EVELYN: And I whispered back to you, I said....

ADAM: I remember.

EVELYN: I meant that. I did.

ADAM: Yeah?

EVELYN: Yes.

ADAM: ...oh.

(She starts to say something else but catches herself. She goes out. ADAM stands alone in the quiet room, looking about.)

(Silence. Darkness)

END OF PLAY